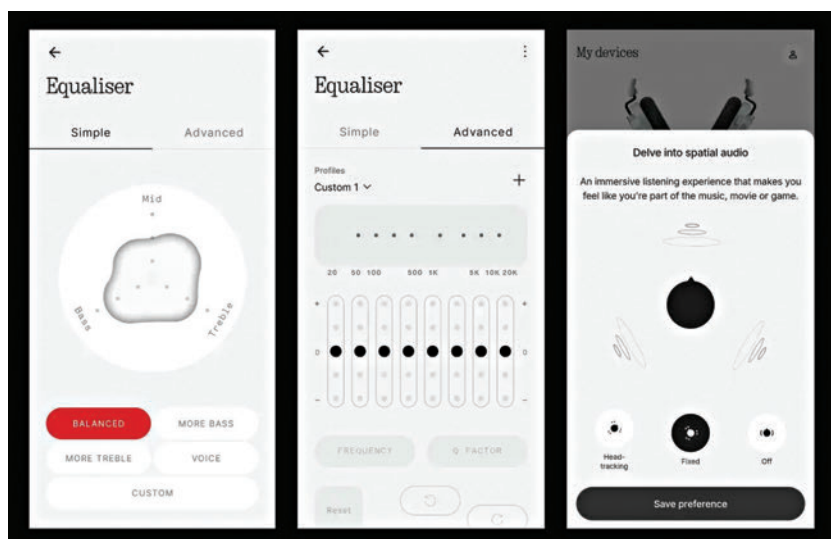




room-shaking rumble that bassheads might seek. In more layered compositions like Selkies, Strobe, and Giorgio by Moroder, the headphones maintain good separation, allowing individual elements to breathe without sounding congested. On Seedhe Maut's Nayaab and Shakti Aur Kshama, the headphones impress with their soundstage, spatial depth, vocals, ad-libs, and instrumentation are cleanly placed, resulting in a well-shaped stereo image.

Highs are handled with restraint, present but never sharp or fatiguing. This helps avoid sibilance on brighter tracks like Centuries, but at times it can slightly dull the sparkle in songs that rely on upper treble. Vocals, particularly in mid-heavy or emotional pieces like Hello by Adele, are clear and natural, though they lack a certain depth or fullness in the lower midrange. This slightly reserved mid tuning may leave some vocal-centric tracks feeling less expressive than they could be.

Still, clarity remains strong across genres. RED and 101 demonstrate the headphone's ability to balance grit and precision, delivering punchy low-end without masking details. Acoustic tracks like Choti Si Asha and Around the World retain their warmth and timbre, and on Billie Jean, each element remains tight and cohesive, proof that the tuning favours balance and cleanliness over showy colouration.

ANC, TRANSPARENCY AND MIC QUALITY

Nothing's ANC isn't Bose or Sony level, but it's no slouch either. On High, it blocks out most urban noise like AC hums or traffic without making your ears feel like they're stuck in a vacuum. There are Mid, Low, and Adaptive modes too, though the latter is a bit hit-or-miss. Transparency Mode, on the other hand, is very natural. You can hold a conversation without taking them off.

Microphone performance is bolstered by six mics and Clear Voice Technology, which uses AI trained on millions of real-world scenarios. Call clarity remained strong across a variety of environments, including cafés and moderately windy conditions.

Head-tracking and spatial audio are baked in. Spatialiser makes stereo sound more roomy, and the head-tracking keeps the 360 feel in check. Not as immersive as AirPods Max, but good enough for movies and casual gaming.

BATTERY LIFE

Battery life is one of the standout features of the Headphone 1. On AAC with ANC off, it delivers up to 60 hours of continuous playback and 32 hours with ANC enabled. You can switch to LDAC from the app for more resolution, but that drops the battery to about 45 hours. With ANC and LDAC on, it goes to around 26 hours which is not bad at

all. A quick 5-minute charge provides roughly 2.4 hours of playback with ANC on, making it easy to top up on the go.

CONNECTIVITY AND OTHER FEATURES

Bluetooth 5.3 ensures stable connectivity, and the headphone supports dual-device pairing, allowing seamless switching between devices. It also supports wired connections via USB-C and a 3.5mm jack, although only volume and ANC controls function in wired mode. Playback or skip controls are not available when plugged in, which limits usability in certain setups.

Additional smart features include on-head detection, low-latency mode for gaming, LDAC support for higher audio, and deep integration with Nothing OS devices for features like voice note capture and Essential Space. These integrations are limited to Nothing's ecosystem for now, but may expand in future updates.

VERDICT

At ₹21,999, the Nothing Headphone 1 is not everyone's headphones, and that's why they work. The design will divide opinion but the sound doesn't.

If you're bored of black plastic blobs that all look the same, the Nothing Headphone 1 will appeal to design-conscious users and discerning listeners. That makes it useful and enjoyable.

—Siddharth Chauhan

SPECIFICATIONS

Drivers: 40mm dynamic / 16Ω | RF: 20Hz-40KHz | Frequency Range: 2000Hz | ANC: Yes, real-time adaptive | Mics: 3 mics each side, 6 in total | Diaphragm: PU | Tuning: Sound By KEF | Dimensions: (H) 173.85mm x (W) 78mm x (D) 189.25mm | Weight: 329g | Battery: 1040mAh | Charging: Type-C wired / 120 min for full charge | Connectivity: Bluetooth 5.3, up to 10m

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Read more on Digit.in:
tinyurl.com/yx3dt9fs